‘They must already be proud of you,’ I said. ‘You’re taking the SSB interview, one of the toughest in the country. It also means that you’ve made up your mind to go through the air force’s back-breaking training. The choice you’ve made is reason enough for them to be proud.’

‘I know. I just hope I make it,’ she said. ‘Anyway, what about you, Gunjan? How does it feel to be a privileged child of an army officer?’

I stared at the coffee in my hand. *Was I really privileged?* Her question had brought back a lot of memories. I didn’t have an immediate answer. At the same time, I couldn’t deny the fact that I was raised in the best possible environment, had received the best education, had worn the best clothes and had grown up eating whatever I liked, whenever I liked. If all this qualified as privilege, then maybe I was. Of course, Hema would have thought that being an army officer’s child must have come with its own privileges: free medical facilities, government accommodation, education rebates, free ration, canteen services and what not. That’s how the world looked at army families on the other side of the cantonment’s walls. But it all came at a cost, which I had never really given much thought to—not until that moment.

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July 1982

‘*The state that was once an island of harmony and prosperity is now stained with blood spilt in communal violence. The communal tragedy began in Amritsar in April, where the Bhindranwale group is gaining influence. Prime Minister Indira Gandhi has shown concern over the worsening situation . . .*’ Papaji switched off the radio on hearing this grim headline. ‘God, what has happened to our beautiful Amritsar?’ a concerned Maa commented as the radio chatter died away.

Two years had passed since we had left Amritsar. Papaji had been posted to Jabalpur, but our hearts and minds still ached for our beloved city. ‘I have a feeling it won’t just stop at communal violence,’ Papaji commented as he